

WIPING THE BOWL Dalgrak, a Korean restaurant at Lajpat Nagar, Delhi

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

MANDU: Korean dumplings, steamed, pan-fried, or deep-fried, with fillings like minced meat, tofu and vegetables

KOREAN FRIED CHICKEN: Crispy, double-fried chicken glazed with *gochujang* or soy garlic sauce



JJAMPPONG: A spicy seafood noodle soup with veggies and sometimes pork or squid

JAPCHAE: Sweet and savoury glass noodles, made from sweet potato starch, stir-fried with vegetables and meat

KIMCHI FRIED RICE: Kimchi, or fermented cabbage, is by now a global signifier of 'Korean'. Here, it flavours comfort food



economy that same year, almost 0.3 of its GDP. The Netflix original *Squid Game*, a Korean drama that highlights economic inequality and human greed against the backdrop of a chilling game show, made history as the first foreign-language show to win Emmys, including awards for Best Actor and Director.

Though India first awoke to K-Pop with PSY's hugely popular 'Gangnam Style' in 2012, the Korean Cultural Centre India (KCCI) had started laying the foundation for it when it started organising All-India K-Pop contests from 2011. The regional rounds in Delhi, Mumbai, Chennai, Bengaluru, Kolkata, Hyderabad, Ahmedabad, Bhopal, Itanagar and Kohima this year saw registrations from 1,278 teams across India. The contest has three categories—vocal, dance and rap. "It is touching to see young people in India empathising and communicating with each other through the unified culture of Korean music and K-Pop, despite the large size of the country and the diverse languages and cultures in each region," says KCCI director Hwang Il Yong.

K FOR KOOLTH

What explains the widespread appeal of all things Korean among Indians? "K-Pop challenges traditional masculine norms and does not conform to rigid gender definitions," says Shreya Khaladkar, co-host of the podcast *K-Pop in India*. "Its embrace of femininity and fluid expression are a big part of why it resonates so strongly with women and the LGBTQIA+ community." The popularity of Korean bands owes to the performance aspect, particularly the choreography, production values, positive messaging, and the accessibility fans have to the 'idols', who frequently livestream to engage directly with them. Unlike the US and UK, the K-Pop fandom model has membership tiers that allow fans to make calls, signs and meet-ups with artists.

In India, festivals like K Town, K



RAJWANT RAWAT

FANDOM CENTRAL

H. Subhashree | 31 |

Staff Nurse, Bolangir, Odisha

"Saranghaeyo" (I love you) is not an alien expression to Subhashree, and she has K-Dramas to thank for that. It was in 2019 that the Odisha native chanced on a photograph of BTS member V on an app in her phone. One press of her thumb later, she was immersed in a world of 16-hour-long seasons of TV shows she would spend "whole nights watching" on her days off from work in NCR. "I wouldn't even know how time would pass," she says. She has watched at least 35 such shows, with Netflix, Viki and HiTV being her hunting grounds. Her affinity is for the classical historical genre, with shows like *Hwarang: The Poet Warrior Youth*, *Empress Ki* and *Mr Queen*, which "show (Korea's) culture, dresses and food". She adds, "The places are depicted so well that you feel like going yourself." It's where she feels Indian shows are lacking: "*Hamare yahaan ka culture nahin dikhaaya jaata* (They don't show our culture)." Part of the BTS ARMY since 2016, she proudly displays their poster on her bedroom wall and owns keyrings of Jimin and V. "I like it that they put (social) messaging in their songs," she adds.

—Suhani Singh